FAST

The Great Lent

55 days before Pascha

Duration: 55 days

The longest and most sacred fast. The faithful abstain from all animal products, deepening prayer and repentance in preparation for the Resurrection.

⚖ Linked Feast: The Resurrection (Pascha)

FAST

Holy Week

Week before Pascha

Duration: 7 days

The most intense part of Great Lent. The Church relives Christ's Passion through continuous prayers, prostrations, and readings from every book of the Bible.

⚖ Linked Feast: The Resurrection (Pascha)

FAST

Advent Fast (Nativity)

25 Nov – 6 Jan (16 Hathor – 28 Kiahk)

Duration: 43 days

A joyful fast preparing for the birth of Christ. The Church sings special Kiahk praises throughout the midnight hour during this season.

⚖ Linked Feast: The Nativity

FAST

The Apostles' Fast

After Pentecost

Duration: 15–49 days (varies)

Commemorates the apostles' fasting after receiving the Holy Spirit before going out to preach the Gospel to the whole world.

⚖ Linked Feast: Feast of the Apostles Peter & Paul

FAST

Fast of the Virgin Mary

1–15 Mesori (7–22 Aug)

Duration: 15 days

The faithful fast in honour of the Theotokos, praying and singing hymns of praise to St. Mary before celebrating her Assumption into heaven.

⚖ Linked Feast: Assumption of St. Mary

FAST

Wednesday Fast

Every Wednesday

Duration: Weekly

Every Wednesday, the Church fasts to remember the day Judas conspired with the chief priests to betray the Lord Jesus Christ.

⚖ Linked Feast: Covenant Thursday

FAST

Friday Fast

Every Friday

Duration: Weekly

Every Friday, the Church fasts to remember the crucifixion and death of Christ on the Cross for our salvation. The oldest Christian fast.

FAST

Fast of Nineveh

2 weeks before Great Lent

Duration: 3 days

Recalls the three-day fast of the people of Nineveh after Jonah's preaching. A powerful reminder that repentance can change God's judgement.

FAST

Paramoun of the Nativity

Day before Nativity (if Sun/Mon)

Duration: 1 day

A strict day of preparation before the Nativity feast. The Church prays special hours recounting prophecies of Christ's birth.

⚖ Linked Feast: The Resurrection (Pascha)

⚖ Linked Season: Jonah's Season

⚖ Linked Feast: The Nativity

FAST

Paramoun of Epiphany

Day before Epiphany (if Sun/Mon)

Duration: 1 day

A strict day of fasting before the feast of Christ's baptism. The Church prays and reads prophecies about the revelation of the Holy Trinity.

⚖ Linked Feast: Epiphany / Theophany

FAST

Fast of Heraclius

Begins the week after Pentecost

Duration: Varies

Commemorates Emperor Heraclius' vow to fast when recovering the True Cross from the Persians. No longer widely observed in the Coptic Church.

⚖ Linked Feast: Feast of the Cross

FAST

The Great Lent

55 days before Pascha

Duration: 55 days

The faithful journey through the wilderness of fasting toward the joy of the Resurrection. Each Sunday of Great Lent has a special Gospel theme.

⚖ Linked Feast: The Resurrection (Pascha)

FAST

Wednesday Fast

Every Wednesday

Duration: Weekly

Fasting on Wednesday is one of the earliest Christian practices, recorded in the Didache. It trains the body and nourishes the spirit week by week.

⚖ Linked Feast: Covenant Thursday

FAST

Friday Fast

Every Friday

Duration: Weekly

On the day of the crucifixion, we deny ourselves in gratitude for the One who denied Himself everything for our sake on the Cross.

⚖ Linked Feast: The Resurrection (Pascha)

FAST

Advent Fast (Nativity)

25 Nov – 6 Jan (16 Hathor – 28 Kiahk)

Duration: 43 days

As the world grows dark in winter, the Church prepares to welcome the Light of the World. Kiahk hymns fill the midnight praises with expectation.

⚖ Linked Feast: The Nativity

FAST

Fast of the Virgin Mary

1–15 Mesori (7–22 Aug)

Duration: 15 days

During August, the whole Church turns to the Theotokos in prayer. Many faithful add extra prostrations and special Marian hymns.

FAST

The Apostles' Fast

After Pentecost

Duration: 15–49 days (varies)

This fast varies in length each year because Pascha moves. It always ends on 5 Epep, the Feast of the Apostles Peter and Paul.

⚖ Linked Feast: Assumption of St. Mary

⚖ Linked Feast: Feast of the Apostles Peter & Paul

FEAST

☀️

The Resurrection (Pascha)

Moveable — Feast of Feasts

Christ is risen! The greatest feast of the Christian year. The Church celebrates with joyful hymns, red eggs, and the greeting "Christos Anesti!"

⚖ Linked Fast: The Great Lent / Friday Fast

FEAST

⭐

The Nativity

29 Kiahk / 7 January

God becomes man in a humble manger in Bethlehem. The Coptic Church celebrates with liturgy, carols, and the greeting "Christ is born!"

⚖ Linked Fast: Advent Fast (Nativity)

FEAST

💧

Epiphany / Theophany

11 Tobi / 19 January

Christ is baptised in the Jordan and the Holy Trinity is revealed: the Father's voice, the Son in the water, and the Spirit as a dove.

⚖ Linked Fast: Paramoun of Epiphany

FEAST

🕊️

The Annunciation

29 Baramhat / 7 April

The Archangel Gabriel announces to the Virgin Mary that she will bear the Son of God. Her faithful "Yes" opens the door of salvation.

⚖ Linked Season: Kiahk Season

FEAST

🌴

Palm Sunday

Sunday before Pascha

Christ enters Jerusalem in triumph as the crowds wave palm branches and cry "Hosanna!" The Coptic Church processes with palms and olive branches.

⚖ Linked Season: Holy Pascha Week

FEAST

☁️

The Ascension

40 days after Pascha

Christ ascends to heaven from the Mount of Olives, promising to send the Holy Spirit. The disciples watch as He is taken up in a cloud.

⚖ Linked Feast: Pentecost

FEAST

🔥

Pentecost

50 days after Pascha

The Holy Spirit descends on the apostles as tongues of fire. The Church is born and the apostles begin preaching in every language.

FEAST

✨

The Transfiguration

13 Mesori / 19 August

Christ reveals His divine glory on Mount Tabor. Moses and Elijah appear beside Him, and the Father's voice declares "This is My beloved Son."

FEAST

✝

Feast of the Cross

17 Tout / 27 September

Celebrates the discovery of the True Cross by Empress Helena. The Church processes with candles, recalling the bonfires that signalled the discovery.

⚖ Linked Season: The Fifty Days

⚖ Linked Fast: Fast of the Virgin Mary

⚖ Linked Fast: Fast of Heraclius

FEAST

🌾

Nayrouz (Coptic New Year)

1 Tout / 11 September

The Coptic New Year and Feast of Martyrs. The Church remembers those who gave their lives for Christ and begins a new year of grace.

⚖ Linked Season: Start of the Coptic calendar

FEAST

🌸

Assumption of St. Mary

16 Mesori / 22 August

The Church celebrates the bodily assumption of the Theotokos into heaven. The faithful conclude the 15-day Virgin's fast with great rejoicing.

⚖ Linked Fast: Fast of the Virgin Mary

FEAST

🔑

Feast of the Apostles Peter & Paul

5 Epep / 12 July

Celebrates the two pillars of the Church — Peter the rock and Paul the apostle to the nations. Marks the end of the Apostles' Fast.

⚖ Linked Fast: The Apostles' Fast

FEAST

🌅

Entry into Egypt

24 Bashans / 1 June

The Holy Family flees to Egypt, fulfilling the prophecy "Out of Egypt I called My Son." Egypt is blessed by the presence of Christ as a child.

⚖ Linked Feast: The Nativity

FEAST

⚔

Feast of the Archangel Michael

12 Hathor / 21 November

The Church honours the leader of the heavenly hosts. St. Michael is the protector of the faithful and is commemorated on the 12th of each Coptic month.

⚖ Linked Fast: Advent Fast (begins nearby)

FEAST

📜

Feast of St. Mark

30 Baramuda / 8 May

St. Mark the Evangelist, founder of the Church in Alexandria and author of the second Gospel. He was martyred in 68 AD and his relics rest in Cairo.

⚖ Linked Season: The Fifty Days

FEAST

🌿

Lazarus Saturday

Day before Palm Sunday

Christ raises Lazarus from the dead after four days in the tomb. A foretaste of the general resurrection and a sign of Christ's power over death.

FEAST

🍞

Covenant Thursday

Thursday of Holy Week

Christ institutes the Eucharist at the Last Supper, washes the disciples' feet, and gives the new commandment of love. The Liturgy of the fullest kind.

FEAST

🕯

Bright Saturday

Day before the Resurrection

The Church waits in hope beside the sealed tomb. Christ descends to Hades to free the righteous. Saturday night becomes the vigil of the Resurrection.

⚖ Linked Feast: Palm Sunday

⚖ Linked Fast: Wednesday Fast

⚖ Linked Feast: The Resurrection (Pascha)

FEAST

👋

Thomas Sunday

Sunday after Pascha

The risen Christ appears to Thomas, who cries “My Lord and my God!” Blessed are those who have not seen and yet believed.

⚖ Linked Feast: The Resurrection (Pascha)

FEAST

👶

Feast of the Circumcision

6 Tobi / 14 January

Eight days after the Nativity, the child Jesus is circumcised and named, fulfilling the Law. He who gave the Law submits Himself to it.

⚖ Linked Feast: The Nativity

SEASON

🎶

Kiahk Season

Month of Kiahk (Dec–Jan)

The month of Marian praise. The midnight praises are extended with beautiful Theotokia hymns, building anticipation for the Nativity of Christ.

⚖ Linked Fast: Advent Fast (Nativity)

SEASON

🎉

The Fifty Days

Pascha to Pentecost

The joyful Pentecostal season — no fasting, no kneeling! The Church celebrates the risen Christ for fifty days of unbroken gladness.

⚖ Linked Feast: The Resurrection & Pentecost

SEASON

🐳

Jonah’s Season

Week of Nineveh Fast

The week surrounding the three-day Fast of Nineveh. A season of repentance recalling how an entire city turned from sin back to God.

⚖ Linked Fast: Fast of Nineveh

SEASON

✝

Holy Pascha Week

Week before Pascha

The holiest week of the year. The Church follows Christ from His triumphal entry through the Passion to the sealed tomb, reading the entire Psalter.

⚖ Linked Fast: Holy Week / Great Lent

SEASON

⭐

The Joyful Season

Nativity to Epiphany (7–19 Jan)

Twelve days of celebration between the Nativity and Epiphany. No fasting during this period — the Church rejoices in the Incarnation.

⚖ Linked Feast: The Nativity & Epiphany

SEASON

🏛️

St. Athanasius the Apostolic

7 Bashans / 15 May

The great defender of the faith at the Council of Nicaea. He stood “against the world” to preserve the divinity of Christ against the Arian heresy.

⚖ Linked Season: The Fifty Days

SEASON

⛰️

St. Anthony the Great

22 Tobi / 30 January

The father of monasticism. He withdrew to the Egyptian desert and battled demons, teaching that the spiritual life requires discipline, solitude, and prayer.

⚖ Linked Fast: The Great Lent

SEASON

📜

Pope Kyrillos VI

2 Amshir / 9 February

The beloved 116th Pope of Alexandria, known for his prayer life, miracles, and building the Cathedral of St. Mark in Abbassia, Cairo.

⚖ Linked Fast: Great Lent (nearby)

SEASON

🌿

St. George the Martyr

23 Baramuda / 1 May

One of the most beloved saints in Egypt. He endured seven years of torture rather than deny Christ and is patron of many Coptic churches.

⚖ Linked Season: The Fifty Days

SEASON

🌟

St. Mina the Wonder-Worker

15 Hathor / 24 November

An Egyptian soldier-martyr whose shrine at Mariout became one of the greatest pilgrimage sites of the ancient world. Patron saint of Egypt.

⚖ Linked Fast: Advent Fast (during)

SEASON

📖

St. Demiana the Martyr

13 Tobi / 21 January

A young noblewoman who chose Christ over comfort. She and forty companions were martyred for refusing to deny their faith in Egypt.

⚖ Linked Season: The Joyful Season (nearby)

SEASON

🏙️

St. Cyril the Great

3 Epep / 10 July

The Pillar of Faith who defended the title Theotokos at the Council of Ephesus. His theology shaped the Coptic understanding of the Incarnation.

⚖ Linked Fast: Apostles' Fast (during)

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